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Creative Cultural Studies: encountering African elephants in China

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ABSTRACT

In this essay, I propose an alternative to *Critical Cultural Studies* that I term *Creative Cultural Studies*. In so doing, I explore important shifts scholars are making away from critique, moralism, humanism and rationalism to creativity, becomings, assemblages and affective forces. I look to International Fund for Animal Welfare's (IFAW) ivory campaign to trace how their networked approach to an international problem disrupted connections and shifted affective valences. Beginning with a poster from IFAW's ivory campaign, I trace lines that crisscross among continents, environmental non-government organisations (ENGOS), ivory vendors, flora, fauna, social media and subway riders. To get a feel for what is happening involves less judgment and more encounters with the pandemonium of things.

想象 Xiang Xiang

Standing on the above-ground Wudaokou subway platform in Beijing, one is confronted by two elephants, two elephant arses to be precise, walking into the African sunset. The dialogue suggests this is not a Hollywood ending. A mother and calf are alone on the savannah under a vast sky walking into the gloaming. The calf excitedly declares, 'Mom, I got teeth'. The mother is silent. The calf repeats, 'Mom, I got teeth!' Again, the mother is silent. Again, the excited calf repeats, 'Mom, I got teeth!' After the mother elephant remains silent, the calf asks, 'Mom, aren't you happy I have teeth now?' The mother's silence echoes the death sentence that elephant 'teeth' (ivory) bring. Standing on the Wudaokou platform is a striking moment. The dramatic poster makes all sorts of claims about the world (see [Figure 1](#) below). First, that elephants are facing their sunset, off into the eternal darkness of extinction. Second, that China has something to do with it and can help solve it. Third, that people are moved by affective forces, not disinterested reason. Fourth, that biophilia, kinship, exists, and that anthropomorphising elephants is a way of recognising kinship. Fifth, that consumer networks span the globe and spare no resources, including elephants. Sixth, that China and Africa are entwined in an elaborate and consequential network. Seventh, that media campaigns can traverse and connect continents and nations and people. Finally, that thinking, trade, art and activism are always already global, transgressing boundaries, conventions and laws designed to delimit and domesticate.

Xiang xiang means 'to imagine', but literally it is the two characters for 'think elephant'. These characters are a catalyst for what follows as I trace creative engagements and the fate of elephants. First, a saunter through theory and imagining different perspectives.



Figure 1. ‘Mom, I Have Teeth’. Courtesy: IFAW

Now, all that one needs in order to moralize is to fail to understand.

–Gilles Deleuze (1988b: 23)

Capitalism won. It is a bitter truth for the many scholars labouring in the field of Cultural Studies. In just the past three decades techno-industrial capitalism, despite its flaws and (especially ecological) destructiveness, has transformed the world in extraordinary ways.¹ Putting aside the ubiquitous and irresistible tech marvels that consume, distract and transform us, such as smartphones and social media platforms, much more sober markers have undergone dizzying changes with the adoption of capitalism across the world: global extreme poverty has dropped from 35 per cent of the world population in 1990 to 11 per cent in 2013 despite a population increase of roughly two billion people, with East Asia declining from 60 per cent to 4 per cent; the under-five child mortality rate dropped by more than 50 per cent since 1990, with an 83 per cent drop in China; maternal mortality has declined 43 per cent since 1990; hunger and child labour have markedly declined; life expectancy and access to technology have increased; and so on.

Yet ... defying the world we experience every day, the spectre of Marx still haunts Cultural Studies. Now old, decrepit, tired and revised beyond recognition, Marxism lingers in the academy as the default alternative to capitalism, echoing down the halls of the ivory towers of the humanities and, like Echo, still longing for a response from the reality of our contemporary situation – Marxism has failed as a political practice in the face of capitalism’s successes and widespread embrace and communism’s abject failures, consider the dissolution of the Soviet Union and the ragtag remnants of Venezuela, Cuba and North Korea.

Many of the stunning global statistics are due to China’s dramatic transformation, abandoning Maoist Marxism and turning to ‘capitalism with Chinese characteristics’ starting under Deng Xiaoping in the 1980s and 1990s, which is credited with lifting the country out of extreme poverty to become, once again, a global superpower. Deng touted special

¹Although referring to capitalism in the singular, I am at pains to disclaim any imagined essentialised capitalism and instead argue for the myriad manifestations of capitalisms in ever-changing immanent places. I similarly disclaim any essentialised and pure Marxism, despite how often advocates pursue such a holy grail.

economic zones with the rallying cry ‘*Rang yi bu fen ren xian fu qi lai*’ (‘Let some people get rich first’) and China’s GDP exploded from \$390 million in 1990 to over \$12 trillion in 2018 as the Chinese people embraced capitalism and the benefits that accompanied it (DataBlog 2012).

In the face of the remarkable global changes of the past three decades, however, Marx’s ideas have retained an undeniable gravitational pull. Despite embracing capitalism in our lives as we sip Starbucks lattes, surf Google and order products on Amazon with iPhones, we scholars casually remain neo-Marxist critics of neoliberal capitalism. Yet, if we acknowledge that we live on capitalism’s terrain, how do we start thinking beyond Marxism’s gravity and explore the opportunities and constraints? Furthermore, how do we do the difficult work of creating something new?

In other words, in the wake of the dissolution of the capitalism vs. Marxism binary, how do we think and engage the world? That question is motivated by two realities. First, the capitalism/Marxism binary no longer frames our world and has not for three decades. Second, both capitalism and Marxism are premised on humanism – what is good for people; yet the world is so much more than human. Fifty years ago, on Christmas Eve, 1968, Apollo 8 astronaut Bill Anders took the first picture of earth from space, *Earthrise*, a photo that revealed an earth that far exceeds the human. In this essay, I want to pursue an orientation that accounts for the more than human, this earth teeming with the *pan-demonium of things*.²

In our age of cataclysms, it behooves us to abandon ubiquitous and redundant critiques in order to pursue creation and beauty. Imagine a Cultural Studies dominated not by critique but creativity, not reason and rationality but feeling and affect, not ideology but experience, not subjects but assemblages, not moralism but understanding, not lonely humans but the pandemonium of things. The scholarly task shifts from automatically critiquing capitalism to struggling to understand the world, feeling what is happening instead of remaining mired in a capitalism/Marxism binary.

In this essay, I engage that challenge and offer Creative Cultural Studies as an alternative to Critical Cultural Studies, an umbrella term for a variety of emerging work from a nexus of exciting scholars. After suggesting some of the limitations of Critical Cultural Studies at this historical moment, I sketch the contours of Creative Cultural Studies. In doing so, I recruit thinkers along an alternative ontological line, especially Whitehead, Nietzsche, Deleuze and Guattari, and Latour (with a little help from William James). Through Creative Cultural Studies, I strive to understand becoming worlds composed of creativity, assemblages, things, affective forces, feeling, events and networks. The choice of these thinkers reflects their shared status as heretics outside philosophy proper and, more importantly, their shared feeling about the *sense* of the world that suggests an alternative ontology, which will become evident in the ensuing pages. After outlining the framework and provocations of Creative Cultural Studies, for suggestive purposes I will share the panmediated campaign to save elephants by the International Fund for Animal Welfare (IFAW).

²This phrase points to a gathering of *demos* and *demons*. These connotations are rooted in the Greek *pan* and *daimon*, suggesting the place of all demons. Importantly, the Greek root *daimon* suggests divinity and genius, not evil. The definition of the word pandemonium includes, 1. Wild uproar ... 2. A place or scene of riotous uproar or utter chaos (‘pandemonium’, *Webster’s* 1996: 1401). Thing is also a rich word (see Palsson 2005). A *pandemonium of things* aptly describes the earth, the Internet and the events that compose us, a riotous uproar, a beautiful chaos that changes worlds.

Critical Cultural Studies' Marxist inheritance

I am considering Critical Cultural Studies writ large, including multiple manifestations of cultural studies and large swaths of social theory rooted in and inspired by Marxism in order to elucidate how Creative Cultural Studies is emerging as an alternative orientation and crucial supplement. From Marx through the various permutations of Marxism to Critical Theory to British Cultural Studies to political economy studies to critical rhetoric, Critical Cultural Studies has been committed to key concepts, including *ideology* as false consciousness and mystification except for privileged intellectuals; *class* and more recently the triumvirate of identity politics – race, gender and sexual orientation; *power* usually condensed in a surprisingly abstract centre such as capitalism, the State and now neoliberalism; and *revolution* against a posited centre of power. Marx's explanation of how dominant ideology works inflects Critical Cultural Studies: 'the ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas: i.e., the class which is the ruling material force of society, is at the same time its ruling intellectual force' (Marx and Engels 1970: 64). Although the Critical Theory of the Frankfurt School loosens the economic determinism, a fascination and fear of dominant ideology runs through Critical Theory, from Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* to Marcuse's *One-Dimensional Man*.

Taking its inspiration from the unlikely coupling of Raymond Williams and Louis Althusser, British Cultural Studies explores the cultural manifestations of dominant ideology, making some room for the audience yet retaining 'economic determinism in the last instance'. Stuart Hall embodies these clashing commitments in his seminal essays, especially 'Encoding/Decoding', 'Cultural Studies: Two Paradigms', 'The Problem of Ideology: Marxism without Guarantees' and 'Signification, Representation, Ideology: Althusser and the Post-structuralist Debates'. Hall's work has been cited many thousands of times, with these four articles alone being cited over 14,000 times. And, of course, citations are only part of the story as Hall was clearly the driving force behind and most important figure in British Cultural Studies. The contributions of British Cultural Studies have pushed beyond Marx's structuralism to a deep commitment to humanism and moralism, which has become the backdrop for much of Critical Cultural Studies.

Political economists' incessant if unheeded critique of the concentrated control of media corporations continues apace, too. McChesney's (1999) opus *Rich Media, Poor Democracy* and updates are indebted to Marx's assertion that the ideas of the ruling class become the dominant ideology through ever-increasing concentration of media ownership. While the names change, it seems the practice continues as newspaper and TV tycoons are displaced by the titans of Silicon Valley. Of course, the very need to update the list of the corporate ruling class hints at a crucial issue with the Marxist ruling class claim with respect to theory, reality, determinism and change. The dominant media corporations in Bagdikian's (1997) classic *Media Monopoly* as well as McChesney's work, among others, have been largely displaced by new media corporate giants running utterly different businesses that may not have even existed in the 1980s and, more dramatically, in 2001: Google (Page and Brin); Facebook (Zuckerberg); Twitter (Dorsey), and even Amazon (Bezos), not to mention key actors in our global context, such as Weibo and WeChat in China.

Despite the static world suggested by the power a Marxist stance grants the ruling class and ruling ideology, capitalisms undergo tumultuous transformations at all levels without

Marxist revolutions but via creativity and competition. Just as the 'ruling' railroad tycoons of the 1800s (Stanford, Huntington, Crocker, Vanderbilt) were completely replaced by Detroit's car giants in turn displaced by Toyota, Nissan and Honda; the newspaper barons of the 1900s have utterly disappeared, ruined by the creative changes wrought by TV and now the Internet and social media. In a mere decade (2001–2010) McChesney's opus was made obsolete. The 'ruling class' is a vague and ephemeral moniker. The 'media monopoly' is not much of a monopoly if the ruling corporations keep getting replaced not just by different corporations but entirely new and unimagined businesses. In essentialising and reifying key concepts and categories, Marxism presents a static world that has difficulty accounting for change while waiting for the proper revolution. This point has been made before, prominently by Bourdieu when noting the tendency in Marxism to commit the 'theoretical fallacy' that 'grants reality to abstractions', for example, 'equating constructed classes which only exist as such on paper, with real classes' (1987: 7), but bears repeating.

This cacophony of theoretical commitments plays out in Communication's version of Critical Cultural Studies, represented by journals such as *Communication, Culture & Critique* and amplified by long-standing commitments to humanism and moralism. The emergence of critical rhetoric is beholden to a mishmash of humanist Marxism and a misunderstood Foucault. This is apparent in McKerrow's (1989) seminal essay 'Critical Rhetoric', which insists that the 'critique of domination has an emancipatory purpose – toward which it aims in the process of demystifying the conditions of domination' (91). Adopting Marxist notions of dominant ideology, false consciousness and power, McKerrow claims 'a critical rhetoric seeks to unmask or demystify the discourse of power' (91). The hope in the end is to propose 'intervention strategies [that] might be considered appropriate to effect social change' (91, 92). Noble indeed. Yet, thirty years later, such critiques have yet to disturb the dreams of capitalism.

As this too quick sketch suggests, is hard to overestimate the impact of Marxism on Critical Cultural Studies. Even today, the influence of Marxism persists. Perhaps the biggest cultural studies book of the new century is the global bestseller *Empire* (2000) by Hardt and Negri, already cited more than 17,000 times. Blurbs on the back cover describe it as a 'sweeping neo-Marxist vision of the coming world order' by the 'Marx and Engels of the internet age'. Slavoj Žižek, the Lacanian Marxist academic superstar, wrote a review titled, 'Have Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri Rewritten the *Communist Manifesto* for the Twenty-First Century?'

Such familiar critiques are not limited to the academy. The prominent public intellectual Naomi Klein translates the premises of Critical Cultural Studies into bestsellers – *No Logo*, *The Shock Doctrine: The Rise of Disaster Capitalism* and in 2014 *This Changes Everything: Capitalism vs the Climate* – that have appeared in over thirty languages. As the subtitles suggest, Klein's books are broadsides against capitalism, with her latest critique contending that capitalism is destroying the world: 'our economic system and our planetary system are now at war', thus figuring climate change as a 'battle between capitalism and the planet' (2014: 21, 22). Klein is also popular among academics, with her anti-capitalism trilogy being cited nearly 20,000 times.

Conceptually, the thinking of Critical Cultural Studies remains steeped in Marxism. Marx's concept of dominant ideology, most significantly, remains, well, the dominant

way of understanding power, even after the professed love for Foucault's re-theorisation of power as a:

multiplicity of force relations ... Power is not something that is acquired, seized, or shared, something that one holds on to or allows to slip away; power is exercised from innumerable points ... there is no binary and all-encompassing opposition between rulers and ruled. (1990: 92, 94)

The deification of Obama and demonisation of Trump make evident that Foucault's concept of power is honoured more in the breach and that Critical Cultural Studies scholars are heedless of Foucault's (1990) warning: 'In political thought and analysis, we still have not cut off the head of the king' (88–89). From a Foucauldian perspective, we need a relational, networked understanding of power to begin to grasp how social change occurs. This is readily seen in the incessant finding of concentrations of power in capitalism, neoliberalism, Empire, the West, and US. The overwhelmingly traumatic reaction to President Trump's election victory by academics belied any faith in Foucault's insistence that power is not the prerogative of a king or the privileged dominant class (1979: 26) and revealed an unshakable and visceral belief in centralised power and dominant ideology with Trump embodying the heart of darkness, a physical manifestation and condensation of all evil.³ Against this popular and stubborn conception of power, Deleuze (1988a) sides with Foucault's transformation of power from a property of the centre to diffused strategies and myriad relations: 'Power does not come about through ideology ... A functional microanalysis takes whatever is still pyramidal in the Marxist image and replaces it with a strict immanence' (28). Thus, as scholars interested in thinking outside of a ruling class and dominant ideology, we can employ practices that trace power as dispersed and immanent rather than centralised and transcendent.

Questioning critique

From this focus on a centralised power comes a commitment to negative critique and demystification. The array of thinkers inspiring Creative Cultural Studies offers a sustained questioning of such critique that points scholars in a productive direction. Nietzsche (2001), in *The Gay Science*, gets at the delusive ground of critique – 'How foolish it would be to suppose that one only needs to point out the origin and this misty shroud of delusion in order to *destroy* the world that counts as real, so-called "reality"' (58). Modern thinking, Whitehead noted a few decades later 'criticized and exploded, where it should have striven to understand' (44). Deleuze and Guattari (1994) conclude, 'Those who criticize without creating ... are the plague of philosophy' (p. 28). These thinkers point us away from critique when it does not include the important supplement of creating.

Writing in rebellion against the preceding century of Marxism, Deleuze (with Guattari 1987) excoriates the concept of ideology: 'ideology is a most execrable concept obscuring all of the effectively operating social machines' (68). Ferociously, Deleuze and Guattari (1987) open *A Thousand Plateaus* with a fusillade against ideology:

³This trauma produced a rush of academic commentary. See, for example, the forum in *Women's Studies in Communication* volume 40, number 2, 2017 and the book *Faking the News: What Rhetoric can Teach Us About Donald J. Trump* (2018), the cover of which depicts Trump as the Joker from the Batman movie.

There is no ideology and never has been. All we talk about are multiplicities, lines, strata and segmentarities, lines of flight and intensities, machinic assemblages ... (4)

Deleuze is at pains to distance himself from Marx here because Marx and Marxism remain committed to a conventional ontology and failed political strategy, so Deleuze, in addition to ideology, abandons key Marxist concepts such as class, false consciousness, dialectics, power and the modern subject that recreate problematic binaries and hierarchies. By creating concepts such as multiplicity and assemblage, Deleuze creates something other than a Marxist-inspired Critical Cultural Studies that seeks to understand rather than critique, trace rather than denounce: 'That is why a social field is defined less by its conflicts and contradictions than by the lines of flight running through it. An assemblage has neither base nor superstructure' (Deleuze and Guattari 1987: 90).

As I will explore, for Nietzsche, Whitehead, Deleuze and Latour thinkers are not apart from the world demystifying ideologies and revealing Truth, but immersed in life, immanently connected and composed of multiplicities/assemblages/networks. They cannot perform the detached, privileged academic inhabiting a perch that affords the one True enlightening perspective. Rather, always embodied and emplaced, thinkers are left to grapple with things from multiple partial perspectives. Caught up in abstractions, scholars too often forget this. As Nietzsche (1889) suggests, '"Reason" is the reason we falsify the testimony of the senses' (Part 3, Sec 2). In a direct rebuke to Descartes, Nietzsche (1956) opens the *Genealogy of Morals* with the line, 'We knowers are unknown to ourselves' (149). Deleuze, deeply inspired by Nietzsche, advocates a radical questioning of the West's foundations in the heart of the book that is the core of Deleuze's philosophy: *Difference and Repetition*'s 'The Image of Thought'. In Western philosophy the founding moralistic image of thought assumes a 'thought endowed with a talent for truth or an affinity with the true' (Deleuze 1994: 131). Questioning this forces a move beyond 'this Image which already prejudges everything' and opens the possibility to think in a Deleuzian sense (Deleuze 1994: 131).

More recently, Latour has gleefully scorned the fetish of reason, 'A butterfly flies in a straighter line than a mind that reasons ... We insult, frown, pout, clench our fists, enthuse, spit, sigh, and dream. Who reasons?' (Latour 1993: 186). Undermining the rationality that grounds the Cartesian subject of the 'I think, therefore I am' refashions the subject: 'be prepared to cast off agency, structure, psyche, time, and space along with every other philosophical and anthropological category, no matter how deeply rooted in common sense they may appear to be' (Latour 2007: 24–25). After the subject, there is the play of forces composing assemblages.

In his work, Latour elaborates upon and summarises the deconstruction of critique. In a scathing denouncement of critical intellectuals, Latour and Hermant (2006) mock, 'For many decades the intellectual's job was to rescue the common people from their naïve beliefs ... No goal was more lofty than opening the eyes of the populace by revealing market forces and manipulation of truth behind appearances' (94). Clearly, Latour's (2010) target is a Marxism that ironically is also a theology:

With critique, you may debunk, reveal, unveil, but only as long as you establish ... a privileged access to the world of reality behind the veils of appearances. Critique, in other words, has all the limits of utopia: it relies on the certainty of the world *beyond* this world. By contrast, for compositionism, there is no world of beyond. It is all about *immanence*. (475)

Latour's alternative, compositionism, dismisses false consciousness and the easy critiques that accompany such an assumption in order to map vast and overlapping networks, explore connections, follow movement and understand.

The creative turn

Hinted at in these deconstructions of critique is an alternative emphasising experience, immanence, understanding, assemblage, feeling and creativity. Just as Critical Cultural Studies is founded upon Marx's trenchant critique of capitalism, *Creative Cultural Studies* emerges from Nietzsche's thinking creatively. As Deleuze (1985) puts it, 'Marx and Freud, perhaps, do represent the dawn of our culture, but Nietzsche is something entirely different' (142). Deleuze (1985) explains that Marxism and psychoanalysis are projects of codification and state building, so that 'Marxism and psychoanalysis in a real sense constitute the fundamental bureaucracies – one public, the other private' (142). Nietzsche's thought is counter to this: 'Nietzsche's concern, on the contrary, is not this at all. His task lies elsewhere ... to transmit something that does not and will not allow itself to be codified' (Deleuze 1985: 142). Nietzsche's project is one of creation, not bureaucratic codification. As Deleuze affirms, 'To think is to create – this is Nietzsche's greatest lesson' (1962: xiv). To *create*, not only to *critique*.

Nietzsche (1889) calls on the thinker to 'stand beyond good and evil and treat the illusion of moral judgment as beneath him ... Moral and religious judgments are based on realities that do not exist ... they are always merely absurd' (Part 7, Section 1). Critique too often is bound up with moral judgements in its mission to reveal the *true* meaning of a particular artefact, event or object rather than understanding its diverse connections and relationships to *things* – ideas, objects, beings, networks and so forth. To see beyond good and evil, to resist moralism, to think beyond Truth, is to abandon ideology and Truth as critical tools for thinking, for ideology and Truth assume the true and the false, the Real and illusion, presuppositions that blind thinking and stunt perspectives. For Nietzsche (1956), thinkers 'must first stand not only philosophy but truth itself on its head' (288). *Creative Cultural Studies* aims to engage forces, becomings and assemblages beyond moralism.

As scholars, our task is not to judge an already given, static world and find it false and lacking, but to encounter and explore a ceaselessly changing, creative, eventful pluriverse. *Creative Cultural Studies* requires a shift in orientation that emerges from a shift in ontology. William James sketches a transition from a subject-object universe to a pluralistic universe, from 'I think, therefore I am' to 'I feel, therefore I become'. For academics trained in cultural studies, this can be a difficult shift. James (2018 [1909]) explains,

Reality, life, experience, concreteness, immediacy ... exceeds our logic, overflows and surrounds it ... so I prefer bluntly to call reality if not irrational then at least non-rational in its constitution – and by reality here I mean reality where things happen, all temporal reality without exception. (76)

James' move beyond rationality embraces immanence: 'that distributed and strung-along and flowing sort of reality which we finite beings swim in. That is the sort of reality given us, and that is the sort with which logic is so incommensurable' (76–77).

Amidst this non-rational, ‘great blooming buzzing confusion’ (James 1995 [1890]: 462), Whitehead (1978 [1929]) notes, ‘We find ourselves in a buzzing world, amid a democracy of fellow creatures’ (50), wherein critique and judgment seem somewhat beside the point. Swimming in this buzzing, pluralistic universe amidst a pandemonium of things, ‘Connectedness is of the essence of all things of all types’ and creativity and understanding are higher values/practices (Whitehead 1966 [1938]: 9). A Creative Cultural Studies orientation, then, suggests a move from critique and judgment to understanding and creativity by adopting methods that trace connections, focusing on relationships between *things* (which include non-human actants), understanding agency as distributed, and tending to affective *forces*.

In Nietzsche’s (2001) break from traditional philosophy, he highlights creativity: ‘we can destroy only as creators. – But let us not forget: it is enough to create new names and estimations and probabilities in order to create in the long run new things!’ (58). Although not in any appreciable manner influenced by Nietzsche, Whitehead’s discussions of creativity and understanding amplify and develop Nietzsche’s perspective (and share his optimism!). For Whitehead, creating novelty and beauty are primary. As he puts it, ‘this ultimate is termed “creativity”’ (7). Whitehead (1978 [1929]) suggests “‘Creativity” is the principle of novelty’ (21–22, 222, 348–349), the ultimate metaphysical principle and that “The teleology of the universe is directed to the production of Beauty’ (1955 [1933]: 264). Creativity produces novelty, something new and ‘a new idea introduces a new alternative’, the potential ‘realization of what is not and may be’ (Whitehead 1978 [1929]: 11, 32). Stengers (2014) highlights Whitehead’s focus on creativity in the title of her magisterial tome on *Process and Reality* titled *Thinking with Whitehead: A Free and Wild Creation of Concepts*. Indeed, it seems probable that Whitehead coined the word ‘creativity’ (Meyer 2005). The importance of creativity as the general ground for Whitehead cannot be overstated: “‘creativity” is the universal of universals characterising ultimate matter of fact’ (Whitehead 1978 [1929]: 21). Creating offers a crucial alternative to critique in that it seeks to imagine new ways of understanding the world.

Similar to Whitehead, Deleuze and Guattari privilege creativity over critique. As they write in their last co-authored book, *What is Philosophy?*, ‘The object of philosophy is to create concepts that are always new’ (Deleuze and Guattari 1994: 5; see also 77). It is important to remember that for Deleuze (1994) thinking is encountering something in the world that forces one to think and radically alters understanding (139). Highlighting immanent experience, Deleuze and Guattari (1994) further elucidate, ‘Concepts are not waiting for us ready-made, like heavenly bodies. There is no heaven for concepts. They must be invented, fabricated, or rather created’ (5). We can see here the agreement with Whitehead and the dramatic turn from critique and ideology. For these thinkers there is no realm from which to have privileged access to transcendental truth, no God’s eye view denied mere mortals, and no ability to judge true and false ideologies. There is a profusion of creation, immanent experiences and endless connections: ‘the fundamental essence of our experience, the togetherness of things involves some doctrine of mutual immanence’ (Whitehead 1966 [1938]: 164). As Whitehead (1978 [1929]) concludes, ‘each task of creation is a social effort, employing the whole universe’ (223). IFAW’s panmediated campaigns to save elephants and other iconic megafauna seek to create experiences and assemblages that shift worlds.

想象 *Xiang Xiang: making elephants matter*

The other species sharing the earth with humans are experiencing the sixth mass extinction and a general biological annihilation of wildlife on land, water and air. For instance, 60 per cent of the mass of wildlife on earth has been slaughtered since 1970.⁴ IFAW deploys a panmedia strategy ranging from posters to social media to perform global network activism via affective campaigns on behalf of iconic species, including tigers, rhinos, primates, wolves, whales and, most prominently, elephants. Once numbering over 10 million as recently as 1930, the ferocious sustained slaughter of African elephants has left a meagre population of roughly 400,000 on the brink of extinction. As animals disappear from the world, IFAW attempts to make them present again on social media (Weibo, WeChat, Twitter and so on) and via street furniture advertising on city streets and in subways. For example, IFAW attempts to dislodge elephants from the fatal assemblage/network connected to ivory, poaching, art, medicine and profit and create a new assemblage linking elephants to the economics of conservation, biophilia, tourism and nationalism in Africa and to kinship, parenting, biophilia, Western environmentalism, iconic photography, cultural capital and international prestige in China. Seeking to understand, we find ourselves in a tangle.

The first move in tracing the tangled China-Africa network is to look beyond moralism for an account of shifting conditions in these assemblages. Doing so offers the ability to chart relationships and trace how creation and affective forces function. I do so because the purely moral argument that poaching is *bad* is ineffective in disrupting economic needs and crime networks in African countries and centuries of tradition in China that consider ivory as medicinal, a precious art object, and a sign of social status. As scholars, moving beyond moral-based critiques is difficult. Often writing from privileged positions in the West, scholars too easily erase cultural contexts and different ethical systems in Africa and China to imperially decree and impose their moral values on other people (and beings). For Critical Cultural Studies, reflexivity is too often a haphazard practice, especially in the face of Western 'universal' values. In practice, top-down moral arguments against ivory fall on deaf ears when directed at African poachers who are driven to their trade by the fact that a single adult elephant's tusks 'can be worth more than 10 times the average annual income in many African countries'. (Rosen 2012). One elephant – two ivory tusks worth up to \$100,000 – is a small sacrifice for families stuck in abject poverty and tempted by crime as a way out.

While many scholars practice intellectual imperialism (for example, see Hartnett 2013), China scholar Martin Jacques extensively documents the futility of such practices, especially the demand that China become like the West:

The desire to measure China primarily ... in terms of Western yardsticks, while understandable, is flawed. At best it expresses a relatively innocent parochialism, at worst it reflects an overweening Western hubris, a belief that the Western experience is universal in all matters of importance. (2009: 416)

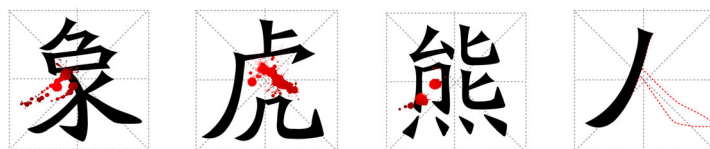
In China, where ivory is linked to medicine and culture, the networks are configured and composed differently. These distinct, dense, and deep-seated ties that connect ivory with

⁴See https://wwf.panda.org/knowledge_hub/all_publications/living_planet_report_2018/ and <http://fortune.com/2018/10/30/wwf-living-planet-report-climate-change/>

the medicinal ability to purge toxins are difficult to reconfigure. So, too, is the perspective that ivory is an art object to be carved. The art of ivory carving dates back to the Shang Dynasty (1800 BCE–1100 BCE) and has long been connected with social standing. When domestic access to ivory dwindled during the Song dynasty (960–1279), the Chinese began importing it from Africa. Ivory was and is regarded as an ideal carving material for fine art, with Beijing and Guangzhou serving as hubs for the finest ivory pieces until the fall of the Qing dynasty. The strength of cultural connections is evidenced by the story of an ivory consumer who ‘seemed unconcerned with the fate of Africa’s herds as she browsed the Beijing Ivory Carving Factory showroom’ (Levin 2013). Though she was aware that elephants must die for ivory, she reportedly said, ‘As long as the quality of the ivory is good, who cares what happened to the elephant’ (Levin 2013). Moral appeals alone were not working here. Affective forces that disrupt habits and networks of trade would prove to be more effective.

Disrupting the hierarchy of the human and encouraging poachers and middle-class ivory buyers alike to value elephants over human desires is a difficult task that requires creative initiatives. As long as humans remain at the top of the hierarchy, every *thing* is ordered in terms of its value in regard to human use and consumption. IFAW’s anti-poaching campaign functions to disrupt anthropocentrism in its series of posters and social media campaigns by situating Chinese buyers in a larger eco-network and appealing to anthropomorphism. This is achieved in a variety of ways. The elephant mother and child poster is one such example of a challenge to anthropocentrism. As viewers stare across the empty platform waiting for the next train to arrive, they see the two elephant rumps moving ever further away as the mom silently walks beside her single offspring. This elephant mother is faced with the prospect of losing her only child due to consumer demand in China for its teeth, something that may resonate with parents affectively and elicit a response and potentially a shift in associations as elephants are recognised as thinking/feeling/speaking beings. The poster is asking viewers to consider elephants as kin, as fellow mammals facing problems that resonate with Chinese viewers instead of hectoring with a moral critique of deficient Chinese.

This is but one poster in the campaign. In Beijing, parades of elephants are part of the everyday subway experience, constantly reminding citizens that Africa and China are connected via ivory. This series of advertisements via affective appeals does important work by reconfiguring the human-elephant assemblage and opening up new ways of considering ivory. First, it seeks to undo the notion that ivory is merely an elephant’s tooth, which is the literal translation of ivory – *ya* (elephant tooth). In campaign pretesting, to their surprise, IFAW discovered that about 70 per cent of the Chinese public did not know that ivory comes from dead elephants. Pulling a tooth is not fatal. Chopping off a tusk is. One poster (see Figure 2 below) makes this crucial point clear. The first row contains the characters for ‘elephant’, ‘tiger’, ‘bear’ and then ‘person’, but in place of one of the strokes of each character representing a non-human animal is blood spatter, an immediate connection to violence. The character for ‘person’ is missing a leg, which is not completed with the same red spatter. The caption reads: ‘An elephant without a tooth, a tiger without a bone, a bear without a gallbladder and a person? Humanity?’ thereby suggesting that to take an elephant’s tooth, a tiger’s bone or a bear’s gallbladder is to lose part of one’s humanity. It also connects the animals in a particular assemblage in which humans are on the same level and makes the claim that human action impacts the viability of these



若象无牙，虎无骨，熊无胆，人？仁？

购买等于杀戮，对野生动物制品说“不”！



Figure 2. ‘Beings Without Humanity’. Courtesy: IFAW.

species, which all happen to be large mammals. The smaller type below reads ‘Purchasing equals murder. Say “NO” to ivory products’. The call to humanity functions to shift the position of ivory from luxury item to a sign of the slaughter of an animal. Instead of enhancing one’s status, purchasing ivory denigrates one’s own humanity.

IFAW’s work to disrupt the poaching industry by targeting consumers is also evident in the social media campaign they launched in the weeks before China’s Spring Festival in 2014. They turned to Sina Weibo, which boasted more than 143 million active users at the time, to discourage people from giving ivory as gifts during China’s most important holiday season. This initiative cleverly tapped into the very important sense of *harmony* in China using word play. IFAW Asia Director Gabriel (2014) writes: “Give Peace to Elephants, Say No to Ivory Gifts” is a clever play on two Chinese words – auspicious and elephant – which share the same pronunciation “Xiang” meaning “all is at peace”. Weibo users were asked to repost the message, and within two days, it had been retweeted 27,000 times. This campaign was bolstered by official action wherein China Central Television (CCTV), the government-run television station, began an awareness-raising campaign linking ivory purchase in China to elephant deaths in Africa by showing images of faceless elephant corpses. These images of chopped up elephant faces elicit horror and disgust, affective provocations that interrupt the world as it is.

IFAW’s use of social media intensifies Foucault’s concept of power from innumerable points. IFAW’s Communication Director in China Jeff He explains their evolving social media strategy:

a much wider media engagement from the perspective of the individuals that everybody is a source of media, a source of content so we’re thinking this is what it means by everybody has the equivalent power, the equal power of speaking.

IFAW is performing with a Foucauldian understanding of power: ‘Power is everywhere ... because it comes from everywhere’ (1990: 93). People moved by witnessing cruelty participate in the movement and amplified via social media become powerful decentred knots of world-making (DeLuca et al. 2012).

These creative efforts to shift understanding that each tusk represents a dead elephant moves ivory from being an art object to symbolising the extinction of one of the world's most charismatic megafauna. Slowly, ivory is transforming from a coveted art piece to a stigmatised item as a result of these campaigns. This requires the shifting of assemblages. Using a panmediated strategy, IFAW was able to influence the affective valence of ivory for buyers and carvers alike, which is necessary if humans are to begin to think of themselves as part of a network rather than the pinnacle of a hierarchy.

Practicing Creative Cultural Studies: tracing assemblages

If the task is no longer to critique and pass judgment from the privileged vantage of an immortal, what is the scholar to do? In *Vibrant Matter* Bennett (2010) also grapples with this same question, starting by quoting Jodi Dean: “If all we can do is evaluate, critique, or demystify the present, then what is it that we are hoping to accomplish?” A relentless approach toward demystification works against the possibility of positive formulations’ (xv). Bennett also cites Foucault’s revealing frustration with critique, ‘I’ve become rather irritated by an attitude, which for a long time was mine, too, and which I no longer subscribe to, which consists in saying: our problem is to denounce and criticize’ (2010: xv).

So, after critique, then what? In a broad sense, it is understanding and assemblage (a creative process) on the plane of immanence. The questioning of critique and reason enables the opening of the earth as a riot of forces, the pandemonium of things that displaces a humanist approach. Thinking via assemblages outside the strictures of humanism opens possibilities. Thinking of humans as residing at the top of a hierarchical pyramid – which undergirds Critical Cultural Studies – posits humans as individual autonomous agents, yet humans can only exist in relationships with the complex ecologies of which they are a part. Every subject is a thing, a gathering, a body, a multiplicity that only becomes when connecting to an assemblage of things. This move suggests shifts in orientations.

In explaining the thinker’s practice, Nietzsche advocates ‘accustoming the eye to calmness, to patience, to letting things come up to it; postponing judgment, learning to go around and grasp each individual case from all sides’ (1976: 511). This means thinking slow, following traces, exploring, foraging ... Understanding trumps critique. In an antecedent to Deleuze, Whitehead proposes ‘assemblage’ as the ground for experience, thinking and creating. As Whitehead (1966 [1938]) explains in *Modes of Thought*, ‘Philosophy can exclude nothing. Thus it should never start from systematization. Its primary stage can be termed *assemblage*’ (2). In this aspect, Whitehead (1966 [1938]) praises James: ‘above all he assembled. His intellectual life was one of protest against the dismissal of experience in the interest of system’ (3).

In Whitehead’s seemingly benign and banal statement, ‘Philosophy can exclude nothing’, lurks a revolution. Western thinking has been chained to various theocracies, from Plato, Christianity, Kant and Hegel, to even Marx. Life is always elsewhere. The assumption is that the world we are immersed in can be remade in the image of some imagined utopia – heaven, ideal forms, universal imperative, Spirit, communism and so on. For Whitehead, all we have is the actual pandemonium of things that surrounds, forms and connects us. Life is here and now.

In the context of assemblage, which I will also develop with Deleuze and Guattari and Latour, Whitehead (1966 [1938]) advocates understanding, not critique, with two

aspects: first, composing, with things grasped as composites via understanding: ‘this mode of comprehension makes evident why the thing is what it is’ (45); and, second, discerning a thing’s ‘capacity for affecting its environment’ (46). This orientation is in concert with Deleuze’s (1988b) orientation to engaging things in the world ‘as a composition of fast and slow speeds, of capacities for affecting and being affected on this plane of immanence’ (125).

Although never particularly concerned about the practical implications of his ontology, Whitehead’s thinking suggests a certain methodological orientation noted by Shaviro (2009): ‘Both Whitehead and Deleuze and Guattari seek to discover new facets of experience: to work out the notions and trace the relations that allow us to encounter aspects of the world, and things within the world’ (149). From this perspective, we are never engaging essences but *things* that are always assemblages, compositions of forces. Taking leave of the rational subject, Deleuze offers bodies as multiplicities and assemblages. Deleuze explodes the body into forces. Instead of an origin of anything, a body is the ‘product of forces of which it is composed ... Every relationship of forces constitutes a body – whether it is chemical, biological, social or political’ (Deleuze 1962: 37). As Deleuze (1988b) suggests, a body exceeds any conventional notions of a human individual, instead existing as a knot amidst a multiplicity of forces: ‘A body can be anything; it can be an animal, a body of sounds, a mind or an idea; it can be a linguistic corpus, a social body, a collectivity’ (127). After the humanist subject, the body is not one of substance but of relations, a cacophonous composition ‘of speed and slowness, of the capacities for affecting and being affected that characterize each thing ... So an animal, a thing, is never separable from its relations with the world’ (Deleuze 1988b: 125). Recent science confirms Deleuze’s perspective with the realisation that 90 per cent of the roughly 100 trillion cells in a human body is composed of other things, an assemblage of others (Sun et al. 2015). Thus, in advancing Creative Cultural Studies, we are also thinking of bodies and societies as compositions of forces, assemblages that are created through relations that are not limited to relations among humans.

To think beyond the limits of a truncated organic human body, Deleuze, often with Guattari, deploys the concepts of multiplicity and assemblage (*agencement*): ‘What is an assemblage? It is a multiplicity which is made up of many heterogenous terms and which establishes liaisons, relations between them ... It is never filiations which are important, but alliances, alloys’ (Deleuze and Parnet 1987: 69). The world is not simply human but wildly relational – ‘each multiplicity is symbiotic; its becoming ties together animals, plants, microorganisms, mad particles, a whole galaxy’ (Deleuze and Guattari 1987: 250). For Whitehead and Deleuze, the world and universe are composed by an endless array of transforming relations among a pandemonium of things that are themselves multiplicities, relations of forces, not substances. To deploy Creative Cultural Studies is to take seriously these theorists’ entreaty to encounter things/assemblages and trace alliances, movements and transformations.

Engaging the world as assemblages of multiplicities, Deleuze and Guattari (1987) suggest not deciphering meaning or unveiling falsehoods or shedding illusions but tracing the forces that compose the many senses of a thing. They write, ‘We will ask what it functions with, in connection with what other things it does or does not transmit intensities, in which other multiplicities its own are inserted and metamorphosed’ (4). Foregoing a quest for meaning and judgment, methodologically Deleuze echoes Nietzsche

and Whitehead, ‘To take the work as a whole, to try and follow rather than judge it Otherwise you just won’t understand it at all’ (1995: 85). From there, ‘To think means to experiment and to problematize’ and ‘to see creation as tracing a path between impossibilities’ (Deleuze 1988a: 116, 1995: 133)

Latour elaborates on methodological orientation in an assemblage – network world in numerous works, at greatest length in the books *Reassembling the Social* and the practical companion piece, *Paris: Invisible City*. For Latour, following Whitehead and Deleuze, tracing, assembling and composing are the primary scholarly activities. Dismissive of abstractions that so mislead thinking, Latour (2007) proposes the study of associations: ‘there is no society . . . but there exist translations between mediators that may generate traceable associations’ (108), which enables the scholar ‘to detect how many participants are gathered in a *thing* to make it exist and to maintain its existence’ (2004: 246). The tracing of ‘the multiplication, enrollment, implication, and folding of non-human actors’ (2007: 193) untangles the pandemonium of things that compose worlds, for example, the composing of Paris: ‘These traces, trajectories, wanderings, partial illuminations, phosphorescences: Paris, the city of light, is weaved by them’ (Latour and Hermant 2006: 5). Only an immanent pluralist empiricism can engage our world of things and networks.

想象 *Xiang Xiang*: shifting ivory assemblages

In the face of the elephant ivory – poaching – art network, I trace IFAW’s efforts to connect elephants to different assemblages and networks. The high value of ivory is driven by demand in countries like China, making African crime networks dependent upon international trade. Several African governments are combating wildlife trafficking by disrupting the pathways of poachers using laws and military force, but this cannot adequately interrupt the networks that drive poachers to kill. To further complicate things, the pathways of poaching are difficult to trace because they change in response to what is happening on the ground. As soon as authorities start targeting one African country, smuggling rings change direction and develop new pathways so the ivory appears to be coming from elsewhere. The crime networks in Africa connect to China as ivory (known as conflict ivory or Africa’s white gold) poached by members of terrorist organisations such as al-Shabab and Uganda’s Lord’s Resistance Army eventually finds its way into the hands of Asian crime syndicates and into markets and auctions in China, the US and other countries. The black market network spans multiple countries and organisations, overlapping with militant groups, terrorists and Chinese consumers.

Thus, when groups like IFAW work to combat illegal wildlife trade, they are confronting a global criminal network akin to and often affiliated with other global criminal networks that traffic in weapons, drugs and humans. Realising this, IFAW has developed a networked approach that seeks to create multiple disruptions. As IFAW’s Gabriel notes,

A lot of the top higher-level officials in the government lack basic knowledge about wildlife crime. They don’t see wildlife crime as important or as devastating to a country or to the ecosystem or to people, as drugs, drug crime, weapons crime, but they are very much linked.

These networks are difficult to obstruct with moral arguments.

Laws alone – like the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species (CITES) agreement to ban international ivory trade – also do not completely shut

down the networks that link buyers and poachers. Though international bans since the 1990s did, initially, help to curb the sale of ivory, before long the illegal ivory trade resumed and the black market flourished. By 2011, poaching was visibly impacting elephant populations across the continent. Without attention to the complex interconnected aspects of the ivory trade, laws could not adequately interrupt international networks in which poverty, customs and corruption create attachments to ivory outside internationally-sanctioned moral frameworks.

IFAW is forced to create conservation networks to counter trafficking ivory and other illegal wildlife commodities: 'because wildlife falls under so many different departments, everybody has a hand in the soup pot, so to speak, so our approach in China, ever since we got in, has been we find collaborations wherever we can'. Of course, such networks are global and require a global response, as Gabriel explains:

Our work around the world actually, if you look at the commercial exploitation of wildlife, we look at every link on the trade chain, from poaching in wildlife habitat to trafficking of parts and derivatives, to reducing consumption and demand. We work in all three, you know, the entire trade chain.

Precisely because the ivory trade relies on international networks, any effort to combat it requires a networked approach. IFAW's networked campaign experiments with how elephants and ivory can be reconfigured within assemblages, creating networks with other ENGOs and corporations, including WildAid, Disney and the global advertising giant JCDcaux. Additionally, IFAW deploys a panmediated strategy that leverages social media feeds, posters on subway platforms, television spots and the movie industry, which is necessary for a global campaign that needs to educate, raise awareness and disrupt affective ties to ivory. A turn to affective forces suggests ways in which assemblages are animated and transformed.

Affective forces: feeling the world

This brings us to our final provocation, which is that affective forces and feelings operate beyond rational reasons. Affective forces are especially important for Creative Cultural Studies. An overweening hubristic humanism rooted in Cartesianism erroneously presumes an autonomous subject moved by rationality, persuaded by good reasons, which obscures the affective forces and feelings that move people and regions and nations and worlds. In uncivil societies, it is misleading to pay myopic attention to models founded upon the superiority of rationality. If Descartes' error, the fetishisation of reason, has long plagued the West, the past 60 years has seen the eruption of affect in the Palace of Reason. The challenge to reason is a challenge to humanism and a move to a flat ontology, with attention to the pandemonium of *things* – scallops, microbes, coffee, ants, Redwoods, corporations, elephants, glaciers, stars, trash, gadgets, cells ... which suggests a transition from a universe of human subjects dominating lifeless objects to affective forces and becomings. As Latour (1993) concludes, 'demonstrations are always of force, and the lines of force are always a measure of reality, it's only measure. We never bow to reason, but rather to force' (p. 233). From this perspective, the things of the earth are no more than compositions, contests, collisions of forces. Changing plays of forces compose new worlds. Deleuze and Guattari (1987) argue

that ‘the essential thing is no longer forms and matters, or themes, but forces, densities, intensities’ (343).

Deleuze proves pivotal in informing the affective turn. Although known for his focus on concepts, Deleuze (1997) also insisted on affect as crucial: ‘Affect, percepts, and concepts are three inseparable forces ... You need all three to *get things moving*’ (137, 165). Attention to affect undermines rationality. The Western fetishisation of reason crumbles. Affect is much more than just personal emotions possessed by a subject. As Abel (2008) elaborates, ‘affect – understood as becoming/pre-subject of force – is precisely that which comes first, ontologically as well as pragmatically; affect is that which ends up producing emotions and representations’ (7). From the view of affective forces, ‘There is no longer a subject, but only individuating affective states of an anonymous force’ (Deleuze 1988b: 128).⁵ Affect moves and is moving. I emphasise movement as characterising affect, because as Deleuze and Guattari (1987) argue, ‘Flows of intensity, their fluids, their fibers, their continuums and conjunctions of affects, the wind, fine segmentation, microperceptions, have replaced the world of the subject’ (162).

I want to supplement the concept of *affect* with *feeling*. While emotion suggests the individual possessions of a Cartesian subject, affect suffers from a certain narrowness and stiltedness. In a sense, this is an accident of translation, with the French verb *affecter* arriving as the awkward *affect* in English. The term *feeling* addresses these issues, offering flexibility, exceeding the individual, being common, yet possessing a certain philosophical richness. Much of that richness comes from the work of Whitehead. In three important books, *Process and Reality*, *Modes of Thought*, and *Adventure of Ideas*, Whitehead offers a relational evental process ontology in which feeling features prominently. Whitehead deserves attention both because he is an important and influential precursor for both Deleuze and Latour and, since he is writing in English, the concept of feeling becomes prominent in his work. This turn to feeling is not alien to Deleuze, who once described affects as ‘new ways of feeling’ (1995: 165).

Whitehead understands becomings of the world as composed of gatherings of things via the perpetual arriving and perishing of events. These becomings occur via feeling. For Whitehead (1978 [1929]), ‘the primitive experience is an emotional feeling, felt in its relevance to a world beyond’ (163; see also 1955 [1933]: 178). The primary activity is feeling the world. Things become through feeling the world. Our primary encounter with the things of the world is through feeling. Echoing others, Whitehead (1955 [1933]) uses ‘Feeling to express the primary activity at the basis of experience’ and recruits William James’ agreement, ‘Sensation is the feeling of first things’ (232). Besides feeling being the basis for how we experience the world, for Whitehead (1966 [1938]) feeling is the basis for knowing and understanding: ‘Feeling is the agent which reduces the universe to its perspective for fact’ (11); and, ‘History is the record of the expressions of feelings peculiar to humanity’ (27). Shaviri (2009) concludes that ‘for Whitehead, the questions of how we feel, and what we feel, are more fundamental than the epistemological and hermeneutical questions that are the focus of most philosophy and criticism’ (47). As Shaviri (2009) elaborates about Whitehead, ‘Feeling, as such, is the primordial form of all relation

⁵Although we rely mostly on Deleuze, affect has exploded in social theory. For paradigmatic examples, see Brian Massumi’s work as well as *The Affect Theory Reader* and Kathleen Stewart’s *Ordinary Affects*.

and all communication ... An act of feeling is an encounter – a contingent event, an opening to the outside’ (63).

Whitehead’s relational process philosophy of feeling signals an epochal shift for philosophy, a shift from the mind and reason to things/assemblages and feeling, from rationality to affective forces. All things are always in process and therefore are happenings, events. A subject is a thing or event. And, as a precursor to flat ontology, any thing is a subject – a person, glacier, tree, bee, virus, star, Chinook Winds and so on. When Whitehead (1978 [1929]) uses the word subject, he prefers the word ‘superject’ to emphasise that the subject emerges from feeling relations amid things in the world: ‘the subject emerges from the world – a “superject” rather than a subject’ (88). As Stengers (2014) puts it in *Thinking with Whitehead*, ‘the actual entity is a “feeling” of “its” world ... I produce myself *qua* feeling that which is not me’ (294–295). Whitehead’s philosophical use of feeling has deep resonances with how we experience worlds, as evident in the many of the uses of the word feeling, and prompts a direction for Creative Cultural Studies: attention to affective forces and feelings in moving people and other things to action.

想象 *Xiang Xiang*: how to feel for elephants on social media

Feelings have long been an important component in environmental campaigns –from encouraging participation to changing relationships and shifting hierarchies. One such example of the force of feeling comes from Gabriel, who organises affective campaigns. Sharing the experiences of many environmentalists, from John Muir’s revelation in the Sierra Nevadas to Ansel Adams first visiting Yosemite to Aldo Leopold watching a wolf die to Julia Butterfly Hill being overwhelmed by Redwoods, Gabriel was called to environmentalism, was made into an environmentalist, through her affective response to a transformative event. An event disrupts the world as it is: ‘The possible does not pre-exist, it is created by the event’ (Deleuze 2007: 234). Deleuze continues, ‘They appear for a moment, and it’s that moment that matters, it’s the chance we must seize’ (1995: 176). For Gabriel, the event involved reporting on caged Asiatic black bears being ‘milked’ for their bile in China:

One of those projects really, really touched me. It was the bears. Seeing these bears ... the first day they came out, they couldn’t even remember the smell of grass or plants. They forgot the feeling of the soil, and the bears just went back and forth on the concrete. And it was just so touching and I felt, this is something China really desperately needs, an organization like IFAW and so I persuaded IFAW to allow me to go back to China and open the IFAW office.

For Gabriel, this experience of feeling touched was a transformative affective event that moved her to not only participate in an environmental campaign, but to found an IFAW office in China. Her experience deeply influences how she designs campaigns, which are aimed at creating feelings in others, as is evidenced by the series of posters she helped to develop. Notably, Gabriel has also found that affective appeals move rapidly across social media networks as social media intensify and accelerate feelings.

IFAW emphasises the affective nature of their campaigns. The touching image of the elephant mother-child interaction on the subway poster is dominated by the image of the two elephants walking into the sunset during their brief conversation. What is missing is an extensive informational campaign about ivory poaching and statistics

detailing the alarming decline of elephants. This is an affective campaign meant to disrupt Chinese commuters' ordinary world – a moment of possible transformation that shifts the relationships in the assemblage from consumers who are strongly tied to ivory-as-art to environmentally aware global citizens who are repulsed by ivory-as-death. IFAW understands Chinese people to be open to such affective appeals. Gabriel explains how the effort is to figure out 'what could touch the audience'.

Affective appeals have become central components to many of IFAW's materials aimed at shifting feelings. By transforming the elephant and her calf into language-wielding creatures, the IFAW poster connects elephants to parents who deeply understand the fear and anxiety surrounding losing an only child. Although China's one-child policy ended in 2016, one of the lingering consequences is that the continuation of many millions of families' lineages is contingent upon the survival of their only child. Thus, parents in China understand the gravity of the elephant mother's plight. Such appeals to the mother-child relationship tap into the anxieties that surround this issue and have the potential to incite action. And it did. In IFAW's ivory campaign, Gabriel described how the mother and baby elephant ad in Guangzhou proved especially powerful:

The whole street, every stall sells ivory. And then at the end of the street is the subway stop. And just turning the corner, you see our ad ... as soon as our ad got into the subway, it kind of exploded. It was the most talked about thing on Weibo for a while. People would take pictures of it with their cellphone and post it on Weibo to discuss it. There was an ivory carver who wrote to us on our Weibo saying that he didn't know and he is not ever going to carve with ivory. There was an ivory trader, a collector, who's been collecting for six years, and day in and day out he goes into the subway, and finally this ad moved him enough that he exposed the ivory trade to the Chinese media. I have heard all this anecdotal feedback on how it has touched people.

Importantly, this poster, which appeared in cities from Beijing to Guangzhou, travelled beyond stationary locations on subway platforms and bus stop benches via camera phones and social media, reaching users all over China and igniting conversations that helped transform connections between people and ivory by changing how people viewed elephants – from a distant object to an animal with struggles akin to humans. The impact of the poster is evident in how far and fast it moved from subway stations to smartphones and the amount of conversation it ignited. The scale of dissemination the poster achieved is possible only in a media-saturated environment in which people have access to mobile media, including smartphones. China has over 700 million internet users, many of whom are connected and highly active on social media platforms including Weibo, Weixin and QQ. It is over these networks that people discuss issues in chat groups, social media feeds and on public forums. IFAW recognises the emerging centrality of social media for activist campaigns and a growing environmental awareness in China. As Gabriel describes,

In the last two years, the explosion of social media and interest in animal issues and the way social media can instantly, just overnight, change the situation. Quite often these kind of animal cruelty atrocities were stopped by social media by Chinese people directly.

This poster travelled so widely that a post-campaign evaluation was difficult because the evaluator had trouble finding people who had not seen the poster. IFAW's ivory campaign spread into networks it never could have planned to touch. Zhejiang's version of the *gaokao*, China's nationwide college entrance exam, included two questions about the

IFAW ivory poaching poster, reaching nine million college applicants. Finally, the IFAW campaign claims direct impact: 'It reduced the segment of people most likely to buy ivory, these are past ivory buyers, it reduced their likelihood of buying ivory from 54% to 26%.⁶

This poster, as well as the one that uses blood spatter in conjunction with Chinese characters, are just two examples of affectively-charged appeals that can shift networks and affiliations. This movement is magnified by the panmediated environment in which Chinese people are immersed and connected. International and national laws passed to ban the trade of ivory, including CITES, are rational and moral responses to the catastrophe of a devastated elephant population, but, as has been argued, they have not been able to adequately disrupt networks of the illegal ivory trade. Laws must be supplemented by affective forces that shift connections between people and elephants and myriad things. IFAW campaigns move beyond laws to disrupt networks. They decrease ivory demand from Chinese consumers by shifting the affective valence of ivory from desire to repulsion and placing elephants and ivory in an environmental assemblage instead of an art-consumer assemblage.

想象 *Xiang Xiang: the ivory in the world*

Over the past few decades, the centuries-old trade networks between China and Africa have intensified and multiplied, thereby reconfiguring the composition of the two overlapping assemblages. China's new economic stature has altered the terms of the China-Africa assemblage, which was previously based on a mutual struggle for development in the face of Western hegemony. China is now the largest single trading partner for sub-Saharan Africa and growing affluence in China intensifies its interest in African resources (Wang and Bio-Tchane 2008). The surge in China's raw material imports from Africa, the growing presence of Chinese manufactured goods in African markets, and Chinese aid to African governments has inspired a variety of relations, practices and conflicts. The emerging twenty-first century China-Africa assemblage is transforming worlds.

The financial ties between China and Africa have strengthened political relationships. These ties only complicate the ivory trade and make the networks between the two countries increasingly dense. The growing China-Africa assemblage impacts trade in oil, weapons and many other commodities, while at the same time accelerating the trade in and decimation of wildlife. Shifting networks and affective valences in China, however, are disrupting these relationships. Grounds for hope do exist. In May of 2013 an IFAW survey (2013) revealed that 60 per cent of the ivory buying public would stop buying ivory if the government made it illegal to do so. The same year, IFAW partnered with Taobao, China's largest shopping website, to discourage consumers from purchasing wildlife products. Using a series of ads, they asked users to report and boycott the sale of illegal wildlife products. The result: 14,000 illegal product listings were removed (Arrest-blog 2013). Efforts directed at interrupting and reconfiguring networks via affective appeals rather than pursuing only moralistic and rational solutions to the slaughter of elephants that simultaneously stems from poverty in Africa and affinity for ivory in China achieved success. Public support for an ivory ban led to the Chinese government

⁶Data on the impact of this poster campaign can be found in the IFAW 'Rapid Asia Flash Report' (<https://s3.amazonaws.com/ifaw-pantheon/sites/default/files/legacy/ifaw-china-ivory-report.pdf>).

banning ivory in 2018. That ban cratered the market for ivory, reducing prices by 65 per cent (BBC 2018). Of course, the 'good' is never simple and always a judgment. From the perspective of African families and Chinese artists dependent on the ivory trade, IFAW's success is potentially disastrous. From an ecological perspective, the ivory ban victory is almost certainly ephemeral as Africa's human population is projected to nearly quadruple by 2100, from 1.2 billion to over 4 billion, leaving little doubt as to the fate of elephants. Ecologically, 'success' is always ephemeral.

In the space of the IFAW ad, which confronts viewers waiting to board the subway train that arrives every two minutes, travellers witness elephants facing their sunset. The many different pieces of visual information are consumed simultaneously. The eyes and the mind bounce quickly between images and characters and link to existing networks. The elephants in danger of extinction are intertwined with China – they transgress national borders and traverse the globe. In a moment on a subway platform, Chinese people are challenged to change their behaviour in order to save an environment thousands of miles away. People who live in a different country, with different laws, customs, rules and beliefs, are being asked to change by a baby elephant and its mom. This baby elephant, so proud of its new 'teeth', becomes a potential moment of connection between people and elephants. The silence of the charismatic megafauna mother gestures to the kinship between all mammals. The mother-child connection – one of the most basic and universal connections across cultures and many species – is tapped in an effort to evoke empathy with a dying species.

This tender moment between mother and child is punctuated with the phrase 'Purchasing equals murder'. Consumption is drawn into the equation. Ivory – a product many Chinese people did not know comes from dead elephants – is now connected. China is joined to Africa through consumption in an elaborate and consequential network. The growing class of consumers in China, who every two minutes replace the crowds of people that stood before them on the Wudaokou platform, are, through this poster, traversing and connecting with other continents, countries and cultures. This panmediated affective campaign moves and moves people via public screens on billboards and smart phones, tweaking the China-Africa assemblage by tinging an economic network with the green hue of environmentalism.

This outline of Creative Cultural Studies is meant to spur questioning and thinking, not foreclose them. Bennett urges that 'demystification, that most popular of practices in critical theory, should be used with caution and sparingly, because demystification presumes that at the heart of any event or process lies a *human* agency that has illicitly been projected into things' (xiv). Thinking otherwise, understanding and creating should be the primary tasks of scholarship that circumvents not only anthropocentrism, but also critique and moralism. How, Bennett asks, might we know the world differently 'if we gave the force of things more due. How, for example, would patterns of consumption change if we faced not litter, rubbish, trash, or "the recycling", but an accumulating pile of lively and potentially dangerous matter?' (viii). Creative Cultural Studies offers scholars the space not simply to critique capitalism, which truncates analysis, but to explore the assemblages and networks that compose worlds.

Creative Cultural Studies is an umbrella term for emerging foci in cultural studies, communication studies, social theory, actant-network theory and animal and plant studies. This growing orientation has the potential to challenge and extend thought and

scholarship in consequential ways by adding new conceptual vocabularies that decentre humans, understand affect as force, and reimagine the world as composed of intricate and moving assemblages. Such is the goal of Creative Cultural Studies – to feel and think the world differently, to understand and explore without presuppositions. Not to critique, but to stretch our minds by creating new concepts to help understand, for example, social movement campaigns through affective forces or humans through the assemblages (micro and macro) that compose us. Using Creative Cultural Studies, scholars can step beyond critique and moralism to examine how change occurs through affective forces and creative becomings. As assemblages and networks shift, we can trace new possibilities for questioning, feeling, thinking, and becoming in a world composed of a pandemonium of things: elephants and poachers and ivory (*ya*) and consumers and bureaucrats and Africas and Chinas and art and money and medicine and guns and social media and savannas and subways and activists.

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